"Throughout my career, I have always been a rebel," says Shanti Dave. "When the Air India people contacted me, they said they needed murals before certain offices of theirs would be inaugurated. Now, most artists like Husain *sahab* would take two-three months for a big job like this one, a mural. But I wanted to finish it in 15 days. I said 'Yes' and told them that my wife would be helping me. Luckily for me, it turned out alright."

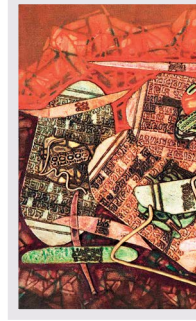
The 91-year-old Dave is being modest, for he is considered one of the more important Indian artists of the 20th century. The aforementioned murals at Air India offices around the world have been acknowledged as exemplars of art in public spaces. His turn towards abstraction, characterised first by encaustics-and-oil combinations in the 1970s and '80s, painstakingly-composed woodcuts and later, smaller and much more colourful palettes through the '90s and the 2000s, shows us the evolution of a truly gifted and instinctive artist.

On the evening of July 14, Delhi's DAG organised the opening night for the exhibition *Shanti Dave: Neither Earth Nor Sky*, curated by Jesal Thacker, a retrospective that included over 80 works from the various stages of the artist's career. Dave was present at the occasion and inaugurated the exhibition as well as the accompanying companion volume (also called *Neither Earth Nor Sky*) of essays about Dave's work. Ashish Anand, CEO and director at DAG, writes in his introductory remarks, "For me, his [Dave's] style and technique are unparalleled. He was India's first major abstractionist to incorporate beeswax into his practice and his encaustic paintings often appear like sculptures in relief. The indecipherable scripts in his paintings appear to me like history having a conversation with itself."

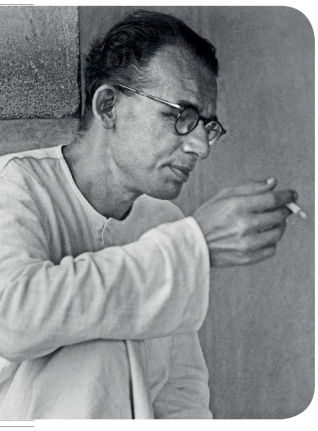
During her curator's walkthrough on this opening evening, Thacker pointed out a crucial aspect of Dave's evolution as an artist—whereas most artists transitioning towards abstraction drew from visual cues, Dave was inspired by sound. In Hindu, Buddhist and Islamic aesthetic traditions, there is an emphasis on chants, mantras, the way







SPEAKING IN TONES
Untitled works by Shanti Dave



ART

Pastoral Dream

Shown in public for the first time recently, a scroll painting by Benode Behari Mukherjee celebrates scenes from rural Santiniketan

(left) Benode Behari Mukherjee at Santiniketan; (below) Scenes from Santiniketan

Where should you witness the brilliance of Benode Behari Mukherjee's just-discovered, 44-foot-long scroll painting? In the pale, yellow-orange glow of neon spotlights in a gallery in Kolkata? Or in the soft, golden-green sunlight filtering in through foliage that reflects off skylights in another gallery, just after a spell of rain, in idyllic Santiniketan?

It's a tough decision because Mukherjee's art, like nature itself, is a different experience at different times of day, and the scroll, dating back to nearly a hundred years ago, reveals a distinct hue depending on when or where you see it. Fortunately, since early this year, it has been on display in galleries both in Kolkata and in Santiniketan.

Called 'Scenes from Santiniketan', the scroll was created by Mukherjee when he was 20 years old. Crafted on layered paper, an influence of the Japanese art that Mukherjee had studied in Santiniketan, it is alternately an ink drawing and a



